DSEH004 · PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT

III

UNIT III READER

# Engagement Strategy

*From engagement data to strategy, across generations, life stages and careers*

Weeks 7 to 9 | Exam preparation | 10 readings explained

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# About this reader

**HOW TO USE IT**

This reader is a companion to the set readings, not a replacement for them. For each reading it explains the argument in plain language, lists the ideas you must hold, shows how to apply them, flags common confusions, and gives questions to think with as you prepare for the end term examination. Read the original first, then use this reader to check your understanding. Folder names refer to the course Readings folder.

Unit III asks how an organization turns what it knows about engagement into a strategy that works at scale. It starts with the drivers and consequences of engagement, moves to the evidence on generational differences and the employee lifecycle, and ends with strengths, careers and sponsorship.

The unit is where popular claims most often outrun the evidence. Generational labels, strengths programs and talent marketplaces are widely sold. A strong examination answer reports what the research actually found, notes the design of the studies, and designs for mechanisms, such as career stage or perceived support, rather than for labels.

**READING MAP**

| Week | Set readings | Folder | Exam edition lectures |
|---|---|---|---|
| 7 | Saks (2006); Macey et al. (2009) Ch 1 and 2; a People Matters or SHRM India case | Unit 2 / Unit 2:Core; case shared in class (Macey et al. not yet filed) | L1 to L3 |
| 8 | Costanza et al. (2012); McKinsey (2022) and People Matters lifecycle articles; Singh and Singh (2019) | Unit 3 / Unit 3:Core and Unit 3:Supplementary | L1 to L3 |
| 9 | Buckingham and Clifton (2001) Ch 1; Cappelli (2008) internal mobility chapter; Hewlett (2013) Ch 1 | Unit 4 / Unit 4:Core (Cappelli and Hewlett not yet filed) | L1 to L3 |

# The readings, one by one

Week 7 Core

Saks, A. M. (2006). Antecedents and consequences of employee engagement. *Journal of Managerial Psychology, 21*(7), 600–619.

### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

In a survey of 102 employees, Saks tested a model of the antecedents and consequences of engagement based on social exchange theory. He found a meaningful difference between engagement with the job and engagement with the organization. Perceived organizational support predicted both; job characteristics predicted job engagement; procedural justice predicted organization engagement. Engagement in turn related to job satisfaction, commitment, intention to quit and citizenship behavior.

### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Job engagement and organization engagement are different.
- They have partly different antecedents.
- Social exchange explains why support produces engagement.
- Engagement links to satisfaction, commitment, intention to quit and citizenship.

**APPLY IT**

When a firm reports one engagement score, ask whether the problem lies with the job or with the organization. Job design fixes the first; fair procedures and support fix the second.

**EASY TO CONFUSE**

This was a small, cross sectional study. Use Christian, Garza and Slaughter (2011) for meta analytic evidence that engagement predicts performance.

**QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**

- Why might fair promotion procedures raise organization engagement but not job engagement?
- What design would test whether support causes engagement?

Week 7 Core

Macey, W. H., Schneider, B., Barbera, K. M., & Young, S. A. (2009). *Employee engagement: Tools for analysis, practice, and competitive advantage*. Wiley Blackwell. Chapters 1 and 2.

### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Macey, Schneider, Barbera and Young present engagement as a source of competitive advantage and describe an engagement value chain: conditions at work make engagement possible, engaged employees feel energy and focus, those feelings show up in behaviors such

as persistence, initiative and taking on more than the role requires, and those behaviors produce performance and customer results.

#### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Engagement runs along a chain from conditions to feelings to behaviors to outcomes.
- Engagement behaviors include persistence, initiative and role expansion.
- Strategy should act on the conditions, not exhort the feelings.

> **APPLY IT**
> Use the value chain to locate where an engagement program acts. A recognition campaign acts on conditions; measuring only satisfaction measures none of the chain directly.

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
> - At which link does a typical annual engagement survey measure?
> - Which link do most engagement programs skip?

**Week 7** Case

People Matters or SHRM India: a selected case on an Indian engagement transformation (Wipro, Infosys or HCLTech), as listed in the Lesson Plan.

#### HOW TO READ IT

Read the case with three questions. What did the firm diagnose, and with what data? Which conditions in the value chain did it act on? What evidence does the case give that outcomes changed, and how strong is that evidence? A practitioner case often reports actions more fully than results.

**Week 8** Core

Costanza, D. P., Badger, J. M., Fraser, R. L., Severt, J. B., & Gade, P. A. (2012). Generational differences in work related attitudes: A meta analysis. *Journal of Business and Psychology, 27*(4), 375–394.

#### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Costanza and colleagues meta analyzed 20 studies with 19,961 people, making 18 comparisons across four generations on job satisfaction, organizational commitment and intention to turnover. The differences were moderate to small and essentially zero in many cases. The authors conclude that meaningful generational differences probably do not exist on these variables, that apparent differences are likely due to other factors such as age and career stage, and that interventions targeted at generations may not be effective.

#### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Generational differences in these work attitudes were small, often near zero.
- Apparent differences may reflect age or career stage.

- Targeted generational programs may not work.

**APPLY IT**

Whenever a question invites generational stereotypes, cite this meta analysis and redesign around life stage, career stage or specific needs instead.

**EASY TO CONFUSE**

Twenge et al. (2010) found some differences in work values using a time lag design. The studies measure different things (attitudes to a current job versus values about an ideal job) with different designs. Neither supports stereotyping individuals.

**QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**

- Why can a single survey at one point in time never separate age from generation?
- Design an engagement program for staff aged 20 to 60 without generational labels.

Week 8 Report

McKinsey & Company. (2022, July). The Great Attrition is making hiring harder. Are you searching the right talent pools? *McKinsey Quarterly*.

**THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF**

McKinsey reports that the wave of resignations it calls the Great Attrition had become a renegotiation between employers and workers. Its survey found that the share of workers planning to leave their jobs remained high, at about 40 percent, and identified distinct pools of workers with different priorities. It argues that employers must look beyond traditional talent pools and tailor what they offer to different groups.

**IDEAS TO HOLD**

- Many workers continued to plan to leave their jobs.
- Workers form distinct pools with different priorities.
- Employers compete across industries for talent, not only within them.

**APPLY IT**

Use the report to show that segmentation can be done by priorities and needs rather than by age group. Note that it is a consulting survey, not peer reviewed research.

**QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**

- How does segmenting by priorities differ from segmenting by generation?
- What would you need to know before applying these findings in India?

Week 8 Reading pack

People Matters: selected articles on the employee lifecycle, as listed in the Lesson Plan.

#### HOW TO READ IT

Map each article onto a stage of the lifecycle: entry, growth, peak, transition and exit. For each, ask which theory from Week 8 Lecture 2 explains the moment it describes, such as socialization at entry or the unfolding model of turnover at exit.

**Week 8** Indian context

Singh, S. K., & Singh, A. P. (2019). Interplay of organizational justice, psychological empowerment, organizational citizenship behavior, and job satisfaction in the context of circular economy. *Management Decision, 57*(4), 937–952.

#### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Using a survey of Indian employees and structural equation modeling, Singh and Singh found that organizational justice positively influences psychological empowerment. Citizenship behavior and empowerment both positively influence job satisfaction, and citizenship behavior mediates the influence of justice and empowerment on satisfaction. The authors frame these "human" aspects as supporting a circular economy.

#### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Fairness at work builds empowerment.
- Empowerment and citizenship behavior raise job satisfaction.
- Citizenship behavior carries part of the effect of justice.

#### APPLY IT

Use this reading as Indian evidence that fair procedures matter when an organization differentiates between segments of its workforce.

#### EASY TO CONFUSE

The Lesson Plan lists this paper under the Journal of Indian Business Research. The verified published record is Management Decision, 57(4), 937 to 952, and that is the PDF filed in the Readings folder.

#### QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Which justice dimension is most at risk when a firm offers special deals to high performers?

**Week 9** Core

Buckingham, M., & Clifton, D. O. (2001). *Now, discover your strengths*. Free Press. Chapter 1.

#### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Buckingham and Clifton argue that organizations are built on two flawed assumptions: that each person can learn to be competent at almost anything, and that each person's greatest room for growth is in their areas of greatest weakness. They propose the opposite: that each person's talents are enduring and unique, and that the greatest room for growth lies in their areas of greatest strength. A strength, in their account, combines talent with knowledge and skill.

#### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Talents are enduring and unique to each person.
- The greatest room for growth lies in areas of strength.
- A strength combines talent, knowledge and skill.

> **APPLY IT**
>
> Use the strengths view for development conversations, then add the limits: strengths can be overused (Kaiser and Overfield, 2011) and weaknesses that block the job must still be addressed (Aguinis et al., 2012).

> **EASY TO CONFUSE**
>
> Much of the strengths evidence comes from the organization that sells the assessment. Treat it as a well argued approach, and look for independent tests.

> **QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH**
>
> - When is fixing a weakness the right priority?
> - How would a strengths approach change an appraisal form?

Week 9 Core

Cappelli, P. (2008). *Talent on demand: Managing talent in an age of uncertainty*. Harvard Business Press. Chapter on internal mobility.

#### THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Cappelli argues that firms should manage talent like a supply chain under uncertainty. Rather than relying only on long internal development or only on hiring from outside, they should both make and buy talent, develop people in shorter cycles to reduce forecasting errors, share development costs with employees, and use internal markets for jobs so that employees can move inside the firm instead of leaving it.

#### IDEAS TO HOLD

- Make and buy talent to manage the risk of uncertain demand.
- Shorter development cycles reduce the cost of forecasting errors.
- Internal job markets keep development investments inside the firm.

APPLY IT

Use Cappelli for make or buy questions, with evidence from Bidwell (2011) that external hires were paid more but performed worse at first and left more often.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- What could stop managers from letting good people move internally?
- Why might sharing development costs with employees improve retention?

Week 9 Core

Hewlett, S. A. (2013). *Forget a mentor, find a sponsor: The new way to fast track your career*. Harvard Business Review Press. Chapter 1.

THE ARGUMENT IN BRIEF

Hewlett distinguishes sponsors from mentors. A mentor gives advice and support; a sponsor is a senior person who uses influence to advocate for the protege, opens doors to stretch assignments and promotions, and takes a risk on their behalf. Sponsorship is an exchange: the protege must deliver performance and loyalty in return.

IDEAS TO HOLD

- Mentors advise; sponsors advocate and take risks.
- Sponsorship opens access to stretch roles and promotion.
- Sponsorship is a two way exchange.

APPLY IT

Use sponsorship to explain unequal advancement, then design fair access to it, using Leventhal's rules of fair procedure from Week 8.

EASY TO CONFUSE

Kram (1985) already included sponsorship among the career functions of mentoring. The modern debate is about which functions people actually receive.

QUESTIONS TO THINK WITH

- Why is sponsorship scarcer than mentoring?
- How could a firm make access to sponsors fairer?

# Designing for mechanisms, not labels

The unit repeatedly asks you to segment a workforce without stereotyping it. The table shows how to replace a label with a mechanism that theory can explain.

| Instead of designing for... | Design for the mechanism | Theory or evidence |
|---|---|---|
| "Gen Z" | Career stage and perceived time ahead | Costanza et al. (2012); lifespan theories |
| "Disengaged staff" | Job versus organization engagement | Saks (2006) |
| "High potentials" | Pivotal roles and fair access | Collings and Mellahi (2009); justice theory |
| "Plateaued employees" | Type of plateau: structural, content or life | Plateau research (Week 9 Lecture 2) |
| "Women who leave" | Access to sponsorship and changing priorities | Hewlett (2013); kaleidoscope careers |

**KEY TERMS**

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| Organization engagement | Engagement with the organization as a whole, distinct from engagement with one's job (Saks). |
| Engagement value chain | Conditions lead to feelings, behaviors and outcomes (Macey et al.). |
| Ecological fallacy | Inferring an individual's traits from a group average. |
| Sponsor | A senior advocate who uses influence and takes risks to advance a protege. |
| Internal labor market | Filling jobs from within through rules and career paths rather than open hiring. |

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All references were checked against Crossref, publisher or library records. Works cited in Apply it and Easy to confuse boxes are explained in the lecture slides.